

Homework 1, Week 2

Activity 5

ACTIVITY 5

Read the following paragraphs which provide instances of the use of examples in writing. Identify the number of examples used and comment on whether they support the main idea of each paragraph. Write down your answer on the line provided.

1. Most cultures around the world now have watches and calendars, uniting the majority of the globe in the same general rhythm of time. But that doesn't mean we all march to the same beat. "One of the beauties of studying time is that it's a wonderful window on culture," says Robert V. Levine, a social psychologist at California State University at Fresno. "You get answers on what cultures value and believe in. You get a really good idea of what's important to people." Levine and his colleagues have conducted so-called pace-of-life studies in 31 countries. In *A Geography of Time*, published in 1997, Levine describes how he ranked the countries by using three measures: walking speed on urban sidewalks, how quickly postal clerks could fulfill a request for a common stamp, and the accuracy of public clocks. Based on these variables, he concluded that the five fastest-paced countries are Switzerland, Ireland, Germany, Japan and Italy; the five slowest are Syria, El Salvador, Brazil, Indonesia and Mexico. The US, at 16th, ranks near the middle.

- **The Main Idea:**

Different calendars and rhythm of time influence different countries.

- **The Examples and Comments:**

- The quote of Levine's words about the significance of time to different cultures. Support the main idea that different rhythm of time influence different cultures.
- Levine and his colleagues's measures to rank countries. Make the main idea more convincing by reality.
- The result of the rank: Highlight the influence by contrasting the result of countries in an objective way.

2. Full-time on-campus students work more hours at paying jobs while in college than students did in the 1970s or 1980s. According to an analysis of US Department of Education survey data, today three quarters of full-time college students are holding down jobs. Nearly half of them work 25 hours or more a week. Working while going to school isn't inherently a bad thing—in fact, some studies show that working on-campus for 15 hours or less per week can help foster better academic performance. On-campus jobs, which are often work-study slots, provide a chance for students to deepen their connections to the campus through contact with other students, faculty, and staff. The problem is that more and more students are working off-campus at multiple jobs and for longer hours. Students who work 25 hours or more a week are much more likely to report that work affected their grades and interfered with their class schedule. Grades suffer as

studying time declines and so does the free time to participate in academic clubs and social activities.

- **The Main Idea:**

Full-time on-campus students have more working time in college than 1970s and 1980s'.

- **The Examples and Comments:**

- The analysis of US Department of Education survey data.
Show the main idea by accurate figures.
- The positive influence of appropriate working to students.
State the advantages of appropriate working to students and make the main idea more comprehensive.
- The negative influence of too much working to students.
State the disadvantages of too much working to students to improve the objectivity of

the main idea.

3. Students do not use our campus recycling program sometimes because they are not aware of it. Student Jim Roberts told me that no one had mentioned the school's recycling program to him, at orientation or anywhere else. Another student, Tracy Worsam, even asked about the program at her orientation, but no one there seemed to know much about it, other than to say "we have some blue barrels around campus." Finally, I interviewed several students who live in that old house on the edge of campus. It is not really a fraternity but more of a boarding house. They all told me that they never littered, even though their yard was a mess. Maybe my interview with them and the information I gave them about the blue barrel program will help. Maybe if they understood recycling and had blue barrels in a convenient location, they would recycle their plastic, paper, and glass items.

- **The Main Idea:**

Students in the author's campus do not use the recycling program sometimes without awareness.

- **The Examples and Comments:**

- Some students did not get any information about recycling from others.

State the lack of publicizing recycling program as a reason to the main idea.

- Some students just get vague information about recycling.

Show that there are not enough communication about the recycling.

- Several students want to recycle but did not know how to do it.

Support the main idea by showing the necessary education about the recycling.

- The suggestions of author to recycling.

Tie the phenomenon to the solution and make the main idea more convincing.

4. For contrast, think of the macho stars we love to watch. Think, for example, of Mel Gibson facing down punk marauders in *The Road Warrior*... John Travolta swaggering his way through the early scenes of *Saturday Night Fever*... or Marlon Brando shrugging off the local law in the *The Wild One*. The attraction of the "tough guy" is that he has—or at least seems to have—what most of us (women) lack, and that is an aura of power and control. In an article, feminist psychiatrist Jean Baker Miller writes that "a woman's using self-determined power for herself is equivalent to selfishness and destructiveness"—an equation that makes us want to avoid even the appearance of power. Miller cites cases of women who get depressed just when they're on the verge of success—and of women who do succeed and then bury their achievement in self-deprecation. As an example, she describes one company's periodic meetings to recognize outstanding salespeople: When a woman is asked to say a few words about her achievement, she tends to say something like, "Well, I really don't know how it happened. I guess I was just lucky this time." In contrast, the men will cheerfully own up to the hard work, intelligence, and so on, to which they owe their success. By putting herself down, a woman avoids feeling brazenly powerful and potentially "selfish;" she also does the

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traditional lady's work of trying to make everyone else feel better ("She's not really so smart, after all, just lucky.")

- **The Main Idea:**

The lack of the "tough guy" to women.

- **The Examples and Comments:**

- The attraction of "tough guy" in stars' works.

By compare the men and women to show the lack of the quality of women.

- Quote the words of Miller.

State the phenomenon of women's misunderstanding to make the main idea more convincing.

- The example of women's comments on achievement in company.

Make the main idea more comprehensive.

Text A

Source Text and Paragraph Analysis

Mother Tongue

I am not a scholar of English or literature. I cannot give you much more than personal opinions on the English language and its variations in this country or others. ***(Introduce the identity of the author and the topic of languages)***

I am a writer. And by that definition, I am someone who has always loved language. I am fascinated by language in daily life. I spend a great deal of my time thinking about the power of language -- the way it can evoke an emotion, a visual image, a complex idea, or a simple truth. Language is the tool of my trade. And I use them all -- all the Englishes I grew up with. ***(Show the significance of the language to author)***

Recently, I was made keenly aware of the different Englishes I do use. I was giving a talk to a large group of people, the same talk I had already given to half a dozen other groups. The nature of the talk was about my writing, my life, and my book, *The Joy Luck Club*. The talk was going along well enough, until I remembered one major difference that made the whole talk sound wrong. My mother was in the room. And it was perhaps the first time she had heard me give a lengthy speech, using the kind of English I have never used with her. I was saying things like, "The intersection of memory upon imagination" and "There is an aspect of my fiction that relates to thus-and-thus"--a speech filled with carefully wrought grammatical phrases, burdened, it suddenly seemed to me, with nominalized forms, past perfect tenses, conditional phrases, all the forms of standard English that I had learned in school and through books, the forms of English I did not use at home with my mother. ***(By the experience of special speech the author expressed his thought of the gap between standard English and daily English)***

Just last week, I was walking down the street with my mother, and I again found myself conscious of the English I was using, the English I do use with her. We were talking about the price of new and used furniture and I heard myself saying this: "Not waste money that way." My husband was with us as well, and he didn't notice any switch in my English. And then I realized why. It's because over the twenty years we've been together I've often used that same kind of English with him, and sometimes he even uses it with me. It has become our language of intimacy, a different sort of English that relates to family talk, the language I grew up with. ***(By the example of the talk between author and her husband show the difference of English gradually influenced by environment)***

So you'll have some idea of what this family talk I heard sounds like, I'll quote what my mother said during a recent conversation which I **videotaped** and then **transcribed**. During this conversation, my mother was talking about a political **gangster** in Shanghai who had the same

last name as her family's, Du, and how the gangster in his early years wanted to be adopted by her family, which was rich by comparison. Later, the gangster became more powerful, far richer than my mother's family, and one day showed up at my mother's wedding to pay his respects. Here's what she said in part: ***(State author's idea of transcribing a conversation to compare the difference of language)***

"Du Yusong having business like fruit stand. Like off the street kind. He is Du like Du Zong -- but not Tsung-ming Island people. The local people call putong, the river east side, he belong to that side local people. That man want to ask Du Zong father take him in like become own family. Du Zong father wasn't look down on him, but didn't take seriously, until that man big like become a mafia. Now important person, very hard to inviting him. Chinese way, came only to show respect, don't stay for dinner. Respect for making big celebration, he shows up. Mean gives lots of respect. Chinese custom. Chinese social life that way. If too important won't have to stay too long. He come to my wedding. I didn't see, I heard it. I gone to boy's side, they have YMCA dinner. Chinese age I was nineteen." ***(Utter the conversation totally to enhance the reality and objectivity of the article)***

You should know that my mother's expressive command of English belies how much she actually understands. She reads the Forbes report, listens to Wall Street Week, converses daily with her stockbroker, reads all of Shirley MacLaine's books with ease--all kinds of things I can't begin to understand. Yet some of my friends tell me they understand 50 percent of what my mother says. Some say they understand 80 to 90 percent. Some say they understand none of it, as if she were speaking pure Chinese. But to me, my mother's English is perfectly clear, perfectly natural. It's my mother tongue. Her language, as I hear it, is vivid, direct, full of observation and imagery. That was the language that helped shape the way I saw things, expressed things, made sense of the world. ***(State the situation of author's mother and different understanding among different friends to show the importance of "mother tongue" to my growth)***

Lately, I've been giving more thought to the kind of English my mother speaks. Like others, I have described it to people as "broken" or "fractured" English. But I wince when I say that. It has always bothered me that I can think of no way to describe it other than "broken," as if it were damaged and needed to be fixed, as if it lacked a certain wholeness and soundness. I've heard other terms used, "limited English," for example. But they seem just as bad, as if everything is limited, including people's perceptions of the limited English speaker. ***(The author offers some thoughts about the different English and opposites the meaning of them to show the difference between different English is complicated)***

Significant Words and Phases

- videotape
A magnetic tape recording video.
 - transcribe
Write out from the speech, talking and so on.
 - gangster
A criminal member in a gang. Here refer to an amazing person.
 - life off
live up to
 - mafia
a powerful group
 - belie
represent falsely
 - stockbroker
An agent who buys and sells the stock.
 - fracture
breaking of hard issue
 - wince
The facial expression when suffering from sudden pain.
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Topic Idea

This article through the author's experience personally exposes the overwhelmed distinguishness among different English especially for standard English and daily English.

Structure

The author first introduce the topic of different English by introducing the identity herself. Then through the personal experience to support the topic idea and show the feelings of the author to the difference. At last the author expresses his own opinion to the phenomenon and make the main idea more comprehensive.